The Last Touchy Feely Drama on the American Stage

By Greg Gamble and Lee Howard

ANDY: Hello, good evening, and welcome to the first and final performance of *The Last Touchy-Feely Drama on the American Stage!* I'm Andy McCunn, and I'm here with Pat O'Keefe to bring you all the passion, all the pageantry, all the gooey sentimentalism that's sure to unfold tonight. There's a palpable feeling of anticipation in the air over this crowd as they impatiently crumple their programs and await that inevitable dimming of the houselights. Pat, give us some of your patented prognostications for the evening. What sort of strategies are you envisioning?

PAT: Pow! That's what I predict! [Emerson Tod Fudgee's] gonna come out with both barrels blazing on the first light cue! Exaggerated walks, exaggerated accents! Lots of spray-on gray in the dad's hair -- be watching for that! And don't be surprised if we get a script loaded with family conflicts culled from actual experiences!

INTRODUCTION

What if theater had commentators . . . just like sports. You have to be kidding, you say? Commentators? No way! Just imagine it though . . . The Last Touchy Feely Drama on the American Stage by Greg Gamble and Lee Howard

ANDY: Introspective creature of loneliness or just another ass with a typewriter -- you make the call! Emerson Tod Fudgee first came to the public's attention with his play *Christopher Columbus: Genocidal Fruitcake.* -not that the play was ever performed. But not content with accomplishing nothing, he boldly stepped forward with his next play, *Queer God.* It was a concept piece

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performed entirely in cliche. And then, hot on its heels came 1991's musical extravaganza, *Victims on Parade!*

PAT: A stunner!

ANDY: Certainly, *Victims* is what Fudgee will be remembered for; from the big, splashy, show-stopping dance number, "Compensatiable," right up to the act one finale, where the Ghost of the Dead Shoplifter descends from the heavens and grants the characters the coveted mantle of victim status.

PAT: And not just the characters, Andy, but I think everyone in that audience felt like a victim. Especially at Broadway prices. *Victims* is still an unfinished work, isn't it?

ANDY: No one's really sure. Its run off-Broadway was titanically short, closing after only forty-three minutes. So, it's not known if it has a second or a third act. It is, in fact, Fudgee's longest-running play! Who would've suspected an art form that began in the bold, shark-filled waters courageously charted by the nervy aplomb of Tennessee Williams, Eugene O'Neill and Arthur Miller, could have evaporated into a creatively stagnant, mosquito-infested backwater of emotionally manipulative dreck, celebrating failure as *the* human experience.

PAT: But the "viva la victim" play has indeed become the "Ol' Yeller" of the art world. And somebody's gotta love it enough to take it out back and ka-pow!

ANDY: It's time for the awesome spectacle to commence! *(With overly dramatic. hushed golf-announcer tones.)* A hush falls over the crowd . . . a few stray coughs . . . the creaking of seats . . . *(Shattering the mood.)* Pat! What's the game plan for the opening? Will it be lights up with the first character already on stage, thus thrusting us into the drama? Or are we going to bring

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the lights up slowly and watch him enter, so we can read his history and his personality in his mannerisms, in his gait?

(PAT rushes to take his place by the huge wipe-board. During the rest of his speeches, PAT rapidly sketches out stats and stick-figures to illustrate his postulations and facts.)

PAT: Well, Fudgee 's opened three of his last five plays with the character already on stage, It's an in-your-face approach that's worked well for him. But, major event that this is, I'd look for a little risk taking tonight; possibly the first character making his entrance in an ambient half-glow of a colored gel . . . pink, purple-some emotional hue.

ANDY: And here comes our first character in the half-light dim of. . . a pink gel! Good call, Pat! *(FATHER slowly lowers himself into the chair.)* He . . . takes . . . his . . . seat. . . and the fuse is lit on this powder keg of performing art! *(With nothing happening. ANDY fills the void with random commentary whispered dramatically in quick bursts.)* Here at 7:08 . . . on a Friday evening in June . . . Emerson Tod Fudgee's bold new work . . .*The Last Touchy-Feely Drama on the American Stage* . . . The tension's thick in the air . . . Fudgee needs a success here . . . . *(Lights up to full.)* And it's lights up! We have lights at full on Emerson Tod Fudgee's *Last Touchy-Feely Drama on the American Stage*! *(Pregnant pause. The ANDY wait excitedly, the FATHER does nothing but read his newspaper.) (Sound fix: Knocking on a door.)* It looks like the drama's under way! Pat, are we going get some blocking out of this door knock?

PAT: From any other director you might get a cross to go and answer the door . . . *(Diagrams an actor's cross to a door. As all wait breathlessly, FATHER shifts in his chair, but never rises.)* But, no! Fudgee's gonna resist the predictable and keep the father stationary . . . *(Draws an. X over the chair and makes a "hundred" circles around it.)* . . . possibly mixing it into the character development somehow! *(Sound fix: Louder knock at a door.)*

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ANDY: It looks like we're coming up on the opening line of *The Last Touchy-Feely Drama on the American Stage!*

FATHER: Come in! *(The SON enters. He is dressed in ill-fitting community theatre prop-room clothes and carries a suitcase.)*

SON: *(stiffly).* Hi . . . Dad.

ANDY: Well, there's obviously some painful memories here!

FATHER: *(scoffing snort).* Hmph! And what's that supposed to mean?

SON: *(confrontationally).* What?

FATHER: *(boiling).* Oh, you heard me!

SON: *(like a human time bomb).* I said, "Hi."

FATHER: *(spitting venom). Liar!*

SON: *(as if he's been hassled for an hour).* All right, all right! I said, "Hi, *Dad!*" Happy?

FATHER: Hmph! *(coming apart).* What, what, *what* would you know about happiness, anyway? Huh? Huh? *Huh?* What would you know about a lifetime of happiness-happy thoughts, happy memories, just *one* happy marriage? Hmm? Hmm? *Hmm? (Takes a long cross and wrings his hands.) Goddammit!* Everywhere-suffocating happiness! Tell, me, Mr. High-and-Mighty, Mr. Showboat, tooling around town shoving your precious G.E.D. in everyone's face, tell me . . . *(Right into SON's face)* . . . how am I *supposed* to feel?

SON: . . . Happy?

FATHER: *(with anomalous cruelty).* What do you think? *(SON pauses, showcasing his full compass of frustrated gestures and false-start mumblings.)*

SON: You . . . You don't want to know!

FATHER: No! *You* don't want to know! *(Something's eating at him.)*

ANDY: Another of those masterful pauses you could drive a truck through! Pat! Are we working towards a revelation?

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PAT: Bet the baby on it, Andy! No crossing to speak of, but look for a tum from profile left to profile right to milk some meaning out of it!

FATHER: *(gazing off into space).* I'm drinking again.

SON: *(drops suitcase).* Oh, my God!

ANDY: No tum, Pat! No tum, no cross and a very disappointing revelation!

PAT: The feeling of underwhelmment coming over this capacity crowd tonight is very real! They want Fudgee swingin ' for the fences! But right when he should've taken a triple toe-loop he singles out of it and two-foots the landing!

FATHER: *(broken and confused).* Why did you come back?

SON: I had to be here for Mom's funeral.

FATHER: That was a year ago!

SON: *(ashamed of his own rage).* Don't you think I know that? *(Tears welling up.)* You never listened to me . . . ever! Wrapped up in your own little hypocritical world, making us all eat your middle-class Spaghettios and your suburban Wonder Bread! *(Lights dim.)*

ANDY: The lights are dimming. Are we headed for an early curtain call?

PAT: *(can't believe his eyes).* No! No! Fudgee, is setting up for the monologue! What's going to happen is they'll take it all down to a single, eerie spotlight, pull an actor forward to the apron of the stage, and have him speak directly to the audience!

ANDY: So, in essence, what we're discussing here is nothing less than the destruction of the fourth wall!

PAT: The total obliteration of it!

ANDY: The father's frozen in tableau and . . . the son is up! Up and headed for the apron of the stage to express for us all the pain we carry with us but can't

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release without geniuses like Fudgee! *(Spotlight on the SON.)*

SON: Will he ever know the real me?

ANDY: A question! Perfect for portraying hope as a straw god!

SON: How do you say, "Dad, I just want you to care! I just want you to hold me"? *(Lights up to full. SON returns to his previous place. FATHER unfreezes, while) (wallowing in drama).* I'm seeing a psychiatrist.

FATHER: *(disgusted beyond belief).* In what way?

SON: *(courageously).* In the only way I know how!

FATHER: I'm ... so sorry.

SON: No, I'm sorry . . . I never told you . . . I'm gay.

ANDY: Oh, my! There's magic in the air tonight! It looks like they're going for the Tony!

SON: Look at me, Dad! I'm gay! I'm gay! I'm gay! I'm gay! Gay, gay, gay, gay, gay, gay, gay! It's not your fault any more than it's not my fault, and it's nobody's fault that it's not anybody's fault!

FATHER: You're not my son!

SON: I'm begging you to accept me and Jeremy!

FATHER: No! I mean you're not my son. You made a confession, now I'm making one! *(Dredging up a painful past.)* Your mother . . . she had an affair . . . on the very day we were married! *(Buries his head. then looks up with his mood swung to a torpid, blank expression.)* It's getting dark outside.

ANDY: *(golf-announcer-esque),* A symbolic line.

SON: *(torpid. blank expression).* And it's so cold already.

ANDY: *(golf-announcer-esque).* And again.

FATHER: Is there something you're not telling me?

SON: You know already.

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FATHER: But I need to hear you say it.

SON: And I need you to hear me say it. I'm . . . I'm . . . *(SON tries and tries to pull some dark secret out of his innards. After stretching out his hands several times with "I'm . . . " he stretches them out and says nothing.)*

PAT: The play-action fake!

SON: I'm . . . *(SON's dreadful attempts at hauling an admission from his soul reach a fever pitch of overacting.)* I'm HIV-positive!

ANDY: And there it is! They're walkin' away with this year's Tony Award!

ANDY AND PAT: Tony! Tony! Tony! Tony! Tony! Tony! Tony! Tony

ANDY: And that'll about wrap it up here for *The Last Touchy-Feely Drama on the American Stage!* Emerson Too Fudgee, previously known as a spectacularly unsuccessful hack, proves in the pinch to be a spectacularly *successful* hack, bidding farewell to an endearingly trite and delightfully derivative theatrical genre that I'm sure will be sorely missed!

PAT: [I'm] Pat O'Keefe

ANDY: [And] this is Andy McCunn saying,

TOGETHER: G'night!

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AWARD HISTORY

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